



Slop / University

Make Your Wait Count

Inside the network turning Slop University's busiest counters into places worth lingering.



An invitation

At any hour of a teaching week, someone at Slop University is waiting — for a form to be checked, an enrolment query resolved, an ID reissued, a question only a person behind a counter can settle. For a long time the University treated that wait as a gap: a queue to be shortened, a number to be called, a place nobody wanted to linger. It no longer sees it that way.



Every service counter on campus now carries its own small screen, and every screen carries more than a number. Between calls it offers a line from a researcher's latest project, a note about a school's open day, a nod to whoever is next. The wait is still a wait. But it has become a setting the University designs for, rather than a delay it merely tolerates.

This brochure is an invitation into that thinking — into the counters, the labs, and the researchers behind the screens above them, and the conviction that runs under all of it: that a university's care for its people shows up as much in how it holds them while they wait as in what it eventually tells them.

Slop University in brief

The University's service counters do a great deal of quiet work, most of it well before anyone notices a number has been called.



A campus that gathers

Every counter collects more than a queue: benches fill, conversations start, a place becomes worth arriving early for.



Every counter, reconsidered

The screen above the desk no longer just counts down to your turn — it carries something worth watching while you get there.



Time, not lost

A wait is treated as time that belongs to the person having it, not simply time the institution is working through.

Where ideas count

The screen that finally has something to say

The Living Dashboard has spent years teaching the University to read its own instruments. Its newest audience is anyone standing at a counter. Working with Student Central, the initiative rebuilt the service-counter screen from the number outward: what plays between calls, how long an announcement lingers, which stories from across the schools earn a slot. The number is still there. It has simply stopped being the only thing on the screen worth reading.



A screen people are already looking at is not a cost. It is an opportunity the University had been wasting.

— Dr Mirela Hanke, Postdoctoral Fellow, School of Continuous Improvement

A counter that remembers you

Return to the same counter often enough and the Adaptive Metrics Lab's instruments start to notice — not who you are, but what the desk tends to see: the questions that repeat, the hour the queue always lengthens, the announcement nobody reads twice. The counter's screen adjusts accordingly, favouring what the University has learned actually holds someone's attention over what it merely hopes will. Staff behind the desk say the effect is subtle. Regulars say the wait feels shorter, even when the clock disagrees.



An indicator that only counts you once has already forgotten you by the time you're back.

— Dr Renke Sabel, Senior Lecturer and Convenor, Indicator Commons, School of Continuous Improvement

Waiting rooms, reconsidered

What began at Student Central has since found its way to the library help desk, the careers service, and the health centre reception — each counter keeping its own screen, its own rhythm, its own small slice of campus life on rotation. The Adaptive Metrics Lab now treats the whole network as a single, distributed instrument: not one queue to manage, but many places where the University gets a chance to be good company while someone waits.



Every counter on this campus is a chance to make waiting mean something.

— Associate Professor Casimir Beng, Lead of the Adaptive Metrics Lab

From our researchers

The thinking behind the network draws on published work from across the University
— read further at slop.university.

- **The Queue as Leading Indicator: Coffee-Cart Waiting Times and Global-Ranking Trajectory** — Two years of queue-length data at the campus coffee cart, read against the University's own ranking trajectory, make the case that even the smallest wait carries a signal worth watching. [doi:10.5555/slop.sn9kzr](https://doi.org/10.5555/slop.sn9kzr)
- **Scanned, Not Seen: Interviewing Student-Society Event Organisers About What Noticeboard QR-Code RSVP Scans Miss About Who Actually Came** — A close look at what a tap of a QR code captures about a student society event, and what it quietly leaves out about who actually showed up. [doi:10.5555/slop.b0njfs](https://doi.org/10.5555/slop.b0njfs)
- **Reserved by Jumper, Missed by the Tally: Cataloguing How Informal Picnic-Table Claims Escape Facilities' Sit-and-Count Tally** — A study of the small, human signals — a jumper on a chair, a laptop left charging — that a courtyard table is claimed, long before any tally counts it. [doi:10.5555/slop.zkfjv5](https://doi.org/10.5555/slop.zkfjv5)

The people behind the work

Associate Professor Casimir Beng leads the Adaptive Metrics Lab, where two decades of experience keeping industrial processes inside tolerance now turn toward keeping campus queues good company. Dr Mirela Hanke, a Postdoctoral Fellow in the same School, works on the Living Dashboard's newest audience: the person who didn't choose to be looking at a screen, but is anyway.

Be part of it

Slop University's counters are open every teaching day, and its network of screens is still growing — from Student Central to every reception where someone might otherwise stand and stare at a wall. If your school, service, or society runs a desk of its own, the Adaptive Metrics Lab and the Living Dashboard would welcome the conversation about what plays above it next.

Come and see what waiting can look like when an institution decides it's worth designing for. Visit a counter, ask a question you don't strictly need answered, and stay long enough to see what's on the screen. The University will be glad of the company.

slop.university



Slop / University